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The Indian Online Seller's Consumer Protection Compliance Kit

E-Commerce Amendment Rules 2026

Notified 9 September 2026 | In force 1 January 2027

WHAT IS INSIDE

17 obligations, rule by rule, with the text to paste · the 13 dark patterns and every CCPA penalty so far
the 30-day price log and 3 compliant display formats · NCH registration and 4 grievance emails
14-field listing sheet · invoice and certificate templates · 8-week calendar · 5 printable audits

2026-27 Edition · 56 days to compliance · Verified against G.S.R. 789(E), 9 September 2026

READ THIS FIRST

The 56-day clock

What this kit is, who it is for, and the one date that decides whether you need it at all

On 9 September 2026 the Department of Consumer Affairs notified the Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) (Amendment) Rules, 2026 — G.S.R. 789(E). The rules come into force on **1 January 2027**. From that morning, every online seller in India is measured against a rulebook that is noticeably stricter than the one we have been living with since July 2020.

This kit exists because the change is quiet. There is no form to fill, no licence to renew, no inspector who visits. The rules simply start applying — and the first time most small sellers will hear about them is a CCPA notice, a marketplace compliance email, or a complaint that suddenly has legal weight behind it.

Who this is for. Anyone in India who sells goods or services online: a D2C brand on Shopify or WooCommerce, a seller on Amazon, Flipkart, Meesho, Myntra or ONDC, a small marketplace of your own, a coaching institute selling courses, a service business taking bookings on its website. If a consumer in India can pay you through a screen, most of this applies to you.

What you get. Not commentary. A decision table that tells you exactly which of the seventeen obligations apply to your business model, a plain-English explanation of each one, the copy-paste text to put on your site, a dark-pattern audit you can run in an afternoon, the 30-day price log that makes the new pricing rule survivable, the grievance-officer system with its four emails, and an eight-week calendar that ends on 31 December 2026 with everything done.

The four dates that matter

Date	What happened	Why you care
23 July 2020	Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Rules, 2020 notified (G.S.R. 462(E))	The base rulebook. Still in force, now amended.
30 November 2023	CCPA notifies the Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Dark Patterns, 2023	Thirteen named patterns that are treated as unfair trade practices.
5 June 2025	CCPA advisory directing e-commerce platforms to self-audit for dark patterns	The regulator told the market to check itself. It then started fining.
9 September 2026	Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) (Amendment) Rules, 2026 notified	Adds the new obligations — and makes the self-audit mandatory, with a certificate.
1 January 2027	Amendment Rules come into force	Compliance date. No transition window announced.

A word on what this is not

This is a practical compliance kit written from the notified text, the regulator's own orders and the Consumer Protection Act, 2019. It is not legal advice and it does not create a lawyer-client relationship. Where a rule is genuinely ambiguous — and one of them, the prior-price rule, is — this kit says so and tells you the conservative reading. If your annual turnover runs into tens of crores or you are raising money, have your counsel read Part 3 alongside this.

How to use it

1. Read Part 2 first. Ten minutes. It tells you which role you play under the Rules and therefore which seventeen obligations apply to you. Most readers will find they are an inventory e-commerce entity, a seller, or both.
2. Then read only your obligations in Part 3. Each is one page: what the rule says, what it means, what to change, and the exact text to paste.
3. Run the dark-pattern audit in Part 4 on your own website on a laptop, with a real card, in a private window. This is where the penalties actually come from.
4. Fix pricing display using Part 5 before your next sale campaign. Diwali-to-New-Year is when most Indian stores run their biggest discount banners, and this is the rule most likely to catch them.
5. Set up the grievance officer and NCH registration in Part 6. It takes an afternoon and it is the obligation most likely to be checked first, because it is the easiest to verify from outside.
6. Work the calendar in Part 12. Eight weeks, one task list per week, ending 31 December 2026.

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Page numbers are indicative — the layout shifts by a page or two depending on your reader. Each part opens on its own page, so the part number is the reliable way to navigate.

PART 1

What actually changed

The seven amendments, in the order they appear in the notification, and what each one costs you if you ignore it

1.1 The seven changes

The amendment runs to a handful of pages and changes seven things. Read this table once and you have the whole reform in front of you.

#	What the 2026 Rules change	Rule	Who it hits hardest
1	New definition of "ranking" — any ordering of sellers, goods or services, by any technology, including algorithms and AI curation	3(1)(j)	Marketplaces; anyone with a "recommended for you" rail
2	Identity block on the platform: legal name, HQ and branch addresses, website, and email + landline + mobile for customer care and the grievance officer	4(2)	Every online store, including single-brand D2C
3	Grievance officer must acknowledge a complaint in 48 hours, send the complainant a copy of the complaint as recorded, and resolve within one month	4(5)	Every online store
4	Imported goods: name and details of the importer, plus full country of origin, per the Legal Metrology (Packaged Commodities) Rules, 2011	4(6)	Anyone reselling imports
5	Every e-commerce entity must become a partner in the National Consumer Helpline convergence process	4(7)	Every online store — including D2C
6	Sponsored listings must be distinctly identified with clear, prominent disclosure; announcing a price cut now requires showing the prior price, defined as the lowest price in the preceding 30 days; the seller's name on the invoice must be the same font size as the platform's; dark-pattern compliance plus a yearly self-audit and a displayed compliance certificate	4(12)–4(15)	Every online store; the price rule hits hardest
7	Marketplace and seller duties tightened: seller identity and ratings, ranking parameters, no promoting related sellers without express consent, no bundled fees, richer product data from sellers, GSTIN or MSME number on every listing	5(3), 5(6), 5(7), 6(5), 7(1)	Marketplaces and every seller on them

1.2 Why this is not theoretical

The reason to take 1 January 2027 seriously is that the regulator has already spent two years showing it will act — against companies far larger than yours, on facts that were visible on a phone screen.

The CCPA told Parliament in August 2026 that it had imposed cumulative penalties of about **Rs 20 lakh** on digital platforms for dark patterns. The Lok Sabha annex of 12 August 2026 sets out the case list: **Zepto Rs 7,00,000**, **PhysicsWallah Rs 5,00,000**, **Anuj Jindal (coaching) Rs 3,00,000**, **FirstCry Rs 2,00,000**, **PharmEasy, SpiceJet and McAfee Rs 1,00,000 each**, with IndiGo and BookMyShow also pulled up and directed to change their interfaces. Thirty-one

platforms filed self-declarations under the 5 June 2025 advisory.

Read those seven cases carefully in Part 4 and a pattern appears: none of them was fined for anything exotic. A pre-ticked donation box. A GST figure added at checkout after a price was advertised. A "24-hour" timer that reset. A renewal screen that labelled the opt-out "Accept Risk". These are the exact things a small Indian store does because a theme, a plugin or a growth hack suggested it.

The sentence to remember

"Consumer consent cannot be assumed through pre-selected options and must always be obtained through a clear and affirmative action." That is the CCPA's own reasoning in the PhysicsWallah order of 3 June 2026, and it is the single most transferable line in the entire enforcement record. Every pre-tick, every greyed-out decline, every add-on already in the cart is measured against it.

1.3 What non-compliance actually costs

Three different penalty engines can reach you, and they are often confused. Here they are, separated.

Provision	What it punishes	Maximum consequence
Section 88, CP Act 2019	Failing to comply with a direction of the CCPA under sections 20 or 21 — for example, an order to withdraw a claim, stop a practice or refund buyers	Imprisonment up to 6 months, or fine up to Rs 20 lakh, or both
Section 89, CP Act 2019	Causing a false or misleading advertisement to be made, prejudicial to consumers	First offence: up to 2 years and fine up to Rs 10 lakh. Subsequent: up to 5 years and fine up to Rs 50 lakh
Sections 2(28) and 2(47), CP Act 2019	A misleading advertisement, or an unfair trade practice — the categories the CCPA uses to classify dark patterns	Basis for CCPA directions, refunds, discontinuation orders and the penalties above
Consumer commissions	A consumer complaint for deficiency in service or unfair trade practice — refund, compensation, litigation cost	No upper cap on compensation; small-claims track from District Commission

For a small seller the realistic exposure is not the Rs 50 lakh number. It is the combination that actually hurts: a CCPA direction you must comply with inside a deadline, the refund and discontinuation orders that come with it, the marketplace suspending your listing while it investigates, and the customer complaints that now have a national escalation channel you signed up to. Add the time cost and it is a bad quarter.

PART 2

Which rules are actually yours

Four roles, one decision table, and five business profiles with their exact obligation lists

2.1 The four roles

The Rules do not regulate "online selling" in the abstract. They regulate four roles, and you can hold more than one at a time. Getting your role wrong is the most common way a small seller ends up either over-complying on things that do not apply or — worse — missing the ones that do.

Role	Definition in the Rules	You are this if…
E-commerce entity	Any person who owns, operates or manages a digital or electronic facility or platform for electronic commerce. A seller selling on someone else's marketplace is expressly not one.	You run the website or app the buyer pays on.
Inventory e-commerce entity	An e-commerce entity that owns the inventory of goods or services and sells them directly to consumers.	You sell your own stock on your own website. This is every D2C brand.
Marketplace e-commerce entity	An e-commerce entity that provides a platform and acts as a facilitator between buyer and seller.	Other people's products are listed on your site and you take a commission.
Seller	A product seller or a service provider — anyone offering goods or services for sale on a marketplace.	You list on Amazon, Flipkart, Meesho, Myntra, Ajio, JioMart or ONDC.

Two consequences follow immediately. First, the Rule 4 obligations sit on the **e-commerce entity**, which means a D2C brand on its own domain carries the full weight of Rule 4 — the identity block, the grievance officer, the NCH partnership, the 30-day price rule, the invoice font rule, the dark-pattern certificate. Second, a pure marketplace seller's own rulebook is much shorter — Rule 6(5) and Rule 7(1) — but the marketplace will push the new data fields onto you contractually, because its own compliance depends on the accuracy of what you upload.

The mistake to avoid

Do not assume "I am only a seller, this is the platform's problem." Rule 6(5)(j) now requires you to give the Central Government identification number — GSTIN or MSME registration number — on your listings. Rule 6(5)(d) requires you to declare country of origin, best-before, return and refund terms, warranty, delivery, cost of return shipping and payment modes. If those fields are wrong or blank on your listing, the exposure is yours, not the marketplace's.

2.2 The decision table

Find your column. Read down. That is your work list — nothing more, nothing less.

Obligation (Rule)	D2C own website	Marketplace seller	Small marketplace	Service business
Identity block 4(2)	Yes	No (platform's duty)	Yes	Yes

Obligation (Rule)	D2C own website	Marketplace seller	Small marketplace	Service business
Grievance officer, 48h / 1 month 4(5)	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Importer + country of origin 4(6)	If you sell imports	Via listing data	If listed imports	Rarely
NCH convergence partner 4(7)	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
No search-result manipulation 4(11)(c)	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Sponsored listing disclosure 4(12)	If you run paid placements or boosted products	No	Yes	If you sell placement
Prior price / 30-day rule 4(13)	Yes	Partly — your own price cuts	Yes	Yes
Seller name on invoice, same font size 4(14)	Yes	Platform invoice, but check	Yes	Yes
Dark-pattern compliance + yearly self-audit + certificate 4(15)	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Seller identity and ratings 5(3)(a)	—	—	Yes	—
Return/refund/warranty/ranking disclosures 5(3)(c), (f)	Your own policy pages	—	Yes	Yes, for services
No promoting related sellers without express consent 5(6)	—	—	Yes	—
No bundled fees 5(7)	—	—	Yes	Yes, if you add fees at checkout
Seller listing data 6(5)(d)	Your own product pages	Yes	Yes	Service terms
GSTIN or MSME number on listing 6(5)(j)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Accurate product info 7(1)(a)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

2.3 Five profiles, five work lists

Profile A — D2C brand on Shopify or WooCommerce, own inventory. You are an inventory e-commerce entity and an e-commerce entity. Your list: all of Rule 4 — 4(2), 4(5), 4(6) if you import, 4(7), 4(11)(c), 4(12) if you use a "recommended" or paid-placement rail, 4(13), 4(14), 4(15) — plus 6(5)(d) and 6(5)(j) content on your product pages and 7(1)(a) accuracy. This is the heaviest profile and the one this kit is built around.

Profile B — Marketplace seller only, no own website. You are a seller. Your list: 6(5)(d), 6(5)(j), 7(1)(a). Your job is to complete the marketplace's new attribute fields accurately and to keep your own claims on the listing truthful. Do not put a discount claim on your listing that does not match your actual selling price, because the marketplace's Rule 4(13) compliance now depends on your price data.

Profile C — Hybrid: own site plus marketplaces. Profiles A and B together. The trap here is inconsistency: the price, the return window and the warranty must match across your own site

and every listing. When they do not, the buyer screenshots the difference and files on NCH, where you are now a convergence partner.

Profile D — Small marketplace or multi-vendor platform. Everything in Profile A plus Rule 5: seller identity and ratings, product and policy disclosures, ranking parameters published, no promotion of related sellers without express affirmative consent, no bundled fees outside loyalty or membership programmes.

Profile E — Service business selling online. Coaching, clinics, salons, consultancies, agencies, travel, event bookings, digital products. You are an e-commerce entity for the sale of services. Rule 4 applies in full. "Best before" and "country of origin" do not; your equivalents are the service description, the delivery timeline, the cancellation and refund terms and the grievance path.

PART 3

The seventeen obligations

What each rule says, what it means in plain English, what to change, and the text to paste

3.1 Rule 4(2) — the identity block

> *"Every e-commerce entity shall provide the following information in a clear and accessible manner on its platform, displayed prominently at an appropriate place to its users — (a) legal name of the e-commerce entity; (b) principal geographic address of its headquarters and all branches; (c) name and details of its website; and (d) contact details like e-mail address, landline and mobile numbers of customer care as well as of grievance officer."*

What it means. Four things, all four, all public, all easy to find. Note what is new: a **landline and mobile number** for customer care, not just an email; and the same for the grievance officer. A contact form that generates a ticket number does not satisfy this. A phone number that nobody answers is a risk you are choosing to take.

What to change. One page — call it /pages/contact or /legal/about-us — carrying the block below, linked from the footer of every page, and from the checkout. If you have branches, list them. If you are a proprietorship, your legal name is your own name as it appears on your GST registration, and your address is the principal place of business on that registration.

Paste this

Legal name: [registered name exactly as on GST/MSME certificate]
Registered office: [full postal address], [city], [state], [PIN]
Branch / warehouse: [address] (repeat per branch)
Website: [domain]
Customer care: [email] | Landline: [with STD code] | Mobile / WhatsApp: [+91 ...]
Grievance officer: [name], [designation] | [email] | [landline] | [mobile]
Grievance response: acknowledged within 48 hours; resolved within one month

3.2 Rule 4(5) — the 48-hour acknowledgement

> *"Every e-commerce entity shall ensure that the grievance officer ... acknowledges the receipt of any consumer complaint within forty-eight hours, provides the complainant with a copy of the complaint as recorded by the grievance officer and redresses the complaint within one month from the date of receipt of the complaint."*

What it means. Three duties with three clocks. Acknowledge in 48 hours. Send the complainant **a copy of the complaint as recorded by you** — that is, your written record of what they complained about, not a generic "we have received your email". Redress within one month of receipt.

What to change. The copy-of-complaint duty is the one everybody misses, and it is the one that creates a paper trail against you if you skip it. Build it into the template: your acknowledgement email should restate the complaint in numbered points and end with "this is our record of your complaint; if anything is inaccurate, reply within seven days". Part 6 gives you the four emails.

The three clocks

48 hours — acknowledgement and copy of complaint. 30 days — redressal. Day 31 — the buyer can go to NCH, and because you are a convergence partner under 4(7), the complaint lands in a channel you agreed to be in.

3.3 Rule 4(6) — imported goods

> "*Where an e-commerce entity offers imported goods or services for sale, it shall — (a) mention the name and details of any importer from whom it has purchased such goods or services, or who may be a seller on its platform; and (b) provide for identification of goods and mention the full and complete name of the country of origin of such goods imported into India, as provided under the Legal Metrology (Packaged Commodities) Rules, 2011.*"

What it means. Two data points on the product page for anything that entered India as an import: who imported it, and the full and complete name of the country of origin. "Full and complete name" is the phrase to notice — not a flag emoji, not "EU", not "UAE". Part 8 gives you the field set and the caveats, including the "country of origin" versus "country of assembly" distinction that catches resellers of electronics.

What to change. Add two fields to your product template — Importer and Country of origin — and make them mandatory for any SKU with an import invoice. Then check your existing catalogue for the SKUs where the field is blank. In our experience that is every SKU imported before this year.

3.4 Rule 4(7) — the NCH partnership

> "*Every e-commerce entity shall become a partner in the convergence process of the National Consumer Helpline of the Central Government.*"

What it means. This is the shortest and most operationally demanding clause in the amendment. It is not an aspiration — it is a registration you have to complete, with documents, on the National Consumer Helpline portal. It is the only obligation in the entire amendment that produces a **verifiable public artefact**: either you appear as a convergence partner or you do not.

What to change. Register. Part 6 walks through the form, the two letters you must upload and what to do with the dashboard once you have it. Do this in week one of the calendar, because the registration is the step most likely to sit in a queue.

3.5 Rule 4(11)(c) — no search manipulation

> "*... mislead users by manipulating search result or search indexes having regard to the search query of the user.*"

What it means. If a buyer searches "cotton kurta", the results must actually respond to that query. You may rank by margin, by stock, by sponsored budget — but you may not show results that ignore the query, or quietly substitute a different product because it earns more. With the new definition of "ranking" in Rule 3(1)(j) covering any ordering by any technology, "the algorithm did it" is no longer a defence.

What to change. Audit your search results for the twenty queries your buyers actually type — pull them from your site search logs and from the marketplace's search-term report. If a query returns items that do not contain the query term, that is the problem, and it is usually a bad synonym list or a manual "promoted" override.

3.6 Rule 4(12) — sponsored listings

> *"Every e-commerce entity shall ensure that sponsored listing of products and services are distinctly identified with clear and prominent disclosures."*

What it means. If placement was paid for, say so, where the buyer sees it. "Distinctly identified" rules out a label in the same colour as the background or one that appears on hover only. "Clear and prominent" rules out a tooltip behind an information icon.

What to change. A visible label on the card itself — "Sponsored", "Ad", "Paid placement" — in a contrasting colour, at least as legible as the product title, and not hidden behind an expand. Part 7 gives you the wording and placement rules.

3.7 Rule 4(13) — the prior-price rule

> *"Where an e-commerce entity or the seller announces a price reduction for any goods or services on its platform, it shall indicate the prior price of such goods or services along with reduced price. Explanation — 'prior price' means the lowest price at which the goods or services were offered during the preceding thirty days."*

What it means. The "was Rs 4,999, now Rs 1,299" banner has a new arithmetic behind it. The struck-through figure must be the lowest price at which you actually offered the item in the last thirty days — not the MRP, not last season's price, not a number you picked. If you have been selling at Rs 1,299 for two months, the honest prior price is Rs 1,299, and a "77% off" claim against an inflated MRP is exactly the kind of claim this rule is aimed at.

What to change. Start a price log today — one row per SKU per day, capturing the price a buyer could actually pay. Part 5 gives you the columns, the three compliant display formats and the five habits to stop. This is the single highest-risk item in the amendment for a small store, because discount banners are written by marketing, not by compliance, and they go live on a Friday night.

3.8 Rule 4(14) — the invoice font rule

> *"Every e-commerce entity shall display clearly and prominently in its invoice, the name of the seller in the same font size as that of the e-commerce entity's name."*

What it means. A deceptively simple rule with a real purpose: the buyer must be able to see, at a glance, who they actually bought from. On a marketplace invoice the seller's name has historically been printed small at the bottom while the platform's brand dominated the header.

That ends on 1 January 2027.

What to change. Open your invoice template and measure the two font sizes. Make them equal, and put the seller's name in the header block. If you sell on a marketplace, check the invoice the platform generates for your orders and raise it with seller support if the seller name is set smaller — the obligation sits on the entity, but a non-compliant invoice carries your GSTIN.

3.9 Rule 4(15) — dark patterns, the audit and the certificate

> *"Every e-commerce entity shall comply with the Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Dark Patterns, 2023 and also conduct yearly self-audit to ensure that its platform is free from dark patterns and a certificate to this effect shall be displayed prominently."*

What it means. Three things, and the third is new to Indian e-commerce. Comply with the 2023 Guidelines. Run a **yearly self-audit**. Display a **certificate to that effect, prominently**. Until now the self-audit was an advisory — the CCPA asked platforms to do it on 5 June 2025. From 1 January 2027 it is a rule, and the certificate is the evidence.

What to change. Run the audit in Part 4, fix what it finds, then publish the certificate in Part 11 with a date and a named signatory. Diarise the next audit twelve months out. A certificate with no audit behind it is worse than no certificate, because it is a representation you made to consumers.

3.10 Rule 5(3)(a), (c), (f) — the marketplace's disclosures

If you run a marketplace, Rule 5(3) now requires you to give buyers, before purchase, the seller's business name, address, website, email and ratings, so the buyer can make an informed decision; the return, refund, exchange, warranty, guarantee, best-before, delivery, shipment, payment-mode and grievance details; and — clause (f) — an explanation of the **main parameters** used to rank goods and sellers. After purchase, the specific seller's details must be available on request so the buyer can pursue a dispute.

What to change. Publish a "How we rank products" page. Three to five parameters, in order of weight, in plain language. Part 7 has a template. Do not write "our proprietary algorithm" — that is the answer the clause exists to end.

3.11 Rule 5(6) and 5(7) — consent and bundled fees

Rule 5(6) stops a marketplace from using consumer information it collected to sell, directly or indirectly, the goods of sellers it is related to through common branding, or to promote associated sellers, **without the consumer's express and affirmative consent**. Rule 5(7) stops it from collecting **bundled fees for services unrelated to the platform**, with an exception for loyalty or membership programmes.

What to change. If you run a multi-vendor platform with a house brand, separate the house brand's placements from organic results, label them, and ask for consent before using buyer data to push them. If your checkout adds a fee — packaging, platform, donation, insurance — check whether it is genuinely related to the transaction, and whether the buyer chose it or was defaulted into it. PhysicsWallah's Rs 10 pre-ticked donation cost it Rs 5 lakh.

3.12 Rule 6(5)(d) and (j) — what a seller must publish

> *"... the seller shall provide ... (d) ... complete details of the goods or services, including country of origin, best before or use before date, return, refund, exchange, warranty and guarantee, delivery and shipment, cost of return shipping and payment modes; ... (j) ... the Central Government identification numbers such as GSTIN or MSME registration number."*

What it means. Your listing is now a disclosure document. Fourteen fields, of which two are new in practice: the **GSTIN or MSME registration number** on the listing itself, and the **cost of return shipping** stated up front rather than discovered at the returns counter.

What to change. Part 9 gives you the fourteen-field listing data sheet, filled with a worked example, plus a blank version. Do it once per SKU category, not once per SKU.

3.13 Rule 7(1)(a) — accuracy

Rule 7(1)(a) requires the seller to provide accurate information on return, refund, exchange, best-before, warranty, guarantee, delivery, shipment, cost of return shipping, payment modes and grievance redressal. The word doing the work is **accurate**. A generous return policy that your warehouse does not honour is a Rule 7(1)(a) problem, not a customer-service problem.

What to change. Pick one source of truth — a single policy document — and make the website, every marketplace listing and every canned support reply quote from it. Then check three of your most recent refunds against the stated timeline. If the real process is slower, change the policy, not the customer's expectation.

The one-page summary of Part 3

Identity block and phone numbers (4(2)). 48 hours to acknowledge with a copy of the complaint, 30 days to resolve (4(5)). Importer and country of origin on imports (4(6)). Register on NCH (4(7)). Do not rig search (4(11)(c)). Label sponsored placements (4(12)). Show the real 30-day prior price (4(13)). Seller name on the invoice at the platform's font size (4(14)). Audit dark patterns yearly and display the certificate (4(15)). Publish seller identity, policies and ranking parameters if you run a marketplace (5(3)). No related-seller promotion without express consent, no bundled fees (5(6), 5(7)). Fourteen fields and a GSTIN on every listing (6(5)). Keep all of it accurate (7(1)(a)).

PART 4

Dark patterns: the thirteen, the audit, the record

Every penalty the CCPA has actually imposed, what each company did, and the audit you run before you sign the certificate

4.1 The enforcement record, in full

This is the complete list of dark-pattern action the CCPA reported to Parliament in August 2026 — nine platforms, seven with penalties totalling about Rs 20 lakh. Read the fourth column: in every case the fix was small, cheap and obvious in hindsight.

Platform	Penalty	What the CCPA found	What the fix was
Zepto	Rs 7,00,000	A lower price shown first, then a handling charge and a Zepto Pass membership fee added at checkout — drip pricing plus basket sneaking	All charges shown upfront; the upfront summary must equal the final checkout price
PhysicsWallah	Rs 5,00,000	A Rs 10 donation to the PW Foundation pre-selected at checkout, with emotional messaging to keep it; "free" courses that needed personal data first — basket sneaking, confirm shaming, forced action	Donation opt-in only; consent through explicit affirmative action
Anuj Jindal (coaching)	Rs 3,00,000	A 24-hour countdown timer that was false — false urgency	Advertisements discontinued
FirstCry	Rs 2,00,000	"MRP inclusive of all taxes" displayed, then additional GST charged at checkout — drip pricing	Original and discounted prices displayed as tax-inclusive; additional charges disclosed upfront
PharmEasy	Rs 1,00,000	PLUS membership added automatically to the cart — basket sneaking	Membership became an opt-in requiring consent
McAfee	Rs 1,00,000	Renewal screen offered only "Renew Now" or "Accept Risk" — confirm shaming, interface interference, trick question, forced action	A neutral "Skip" option added
SpiceJet	Rs 1,00,000	A pre-ticked checkbox enrolled buyers into the SpiceClub loyalty programme while the marketing opt-out stayed unticked — trick question, forced action; order dated 14 July 2026	Undertaking of permanent rectification
IndiGo	No penalty reported	Confirm shaming on the app: the decline option read "No, I will take risk"	Wording changed to "No, I will not add to the trip"
BookMyShow	No penalty reported	A Re 1 contribution to BookASmile pre-ticked after ticket confirmation — basket sneaking	Optional contribution

Two lessons. First, **the regulator reads your checkout**. Second, **the amount is not the point** — Rs 1 lakh to Rs 7 lakh is small money to these companies; what hurt was the direction to stop the practice, the disclosure of the order, and the redesign sprint in the middle of a quarter. For a

store doing Rs 30 lakh a year, a Rs 1 lakh penalty plus a forced redesign is a genuinely bad month.

4.2 The thirteen patterns, with a test for each

The Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Dark Patterns, 2023 name thirteen practices and treat them as unfair trade practices under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019. Below is each one with a plain-English test you can apply to a screen in thirty seconds.

Pattern	In one line	The test to run on your own screen
False urgency	Creating a false sense of urgency — a countdown, "only 2 left", "offer ends in 10 minutes" that resets or is not real	Reload the page in a private window. Did the timer reset? Is the stock number real?
Basket sneaking	Adding anything to the cart the buyer did not add — a product, a service, a donation, a fee, a membership	Open the cart. Every line: did the buyer tick it, or did the system?
Confirm shaming	Wording, images or sound that make the buyer feel foolish, guilty or afraid to decline	Read your decline option out loud. Would you say it to a customer's face?
Forced action	Making the buyer do something extra to get what they came for — buy more, subscribe, or hand over personal data beyond what the service needs	Can a buyer complete the purchase, or read the "free" thing, without giving you something extra?
Subscription trap	Making cancellation hard: hidden cancel button, forced call, multiple screens, retention hoops	Time yourself cancelling. If it takes more than three clicks or a phone call, it is a trap.
Interface interference	Design that obstructs or manipulates the decision — pre-selected options, buried information, the decline link in grey 10px	Squint at the screen. What stands out? Is the prominent option the one that makes you money?
Bait and switch	Advertising a bargain to pull buyers in, then the item is unavailable or they end up buying something else	Does the advertised product exist at the advertised price when the buyer arrives?
Drip pricing	Revealing price elements late — taxes, handling, platform fee, delivery, convenience fee at the last step	Compare the price on the product card with the amount on the payment screen. Same number?
Disguised advertisement	An ad dressed as content — a "review", a "news" item, an influencer post with no disclosure	Does every paid placement carry a visible label on the post itself?
Nagging	Repeated requests to buy, subscribe, install the app or turn on notifications	How many times does your site ask for something before checkout?
Trick question	Confusing wording, double negatives or missing information that leads the buyer to the wrong choice	Read every checkbox aloud. Does "tick" mean yes or no?
SaaS billing	Recurring charges without clear upfront disclosure of auto-renewal and how to cancel	Is auto-renewal stated before payment, in the same size as the price?
Rogue malware	Tricking the buyer into downloading something harmful; ransomware via spam	Do you distribute any download, extension or app from your checkout?

The five that catch small Indian stores

Drip pricing (a GST or handling line added at checkout), basket sneaking (a pre-ticked donation, gift wrap, insurance or membership), false urgency (a discount timer that resets), interface interference (a pre-selected shipping option), and trick question (a marketing consent box pre-ticked while the decline is hidden). If you fix only these five you will have cleared the risk for most stores.

4.3 The self-audit worksheet

Run this on a laptop with a real card, in a private window, on a product you have never bought. Mark each row, name the screen, and set a fix date. This worksheet is the record behind the certificate in Part 11 — keep the completed copy.

#	Check	Yes / No	Screen or URL	Fix by
1	A countdown or "ends today" claim exists and resets on reload			
2	Anything is pre-added to the cart (donation, wrap, insurance, membership, fee)			
3	Any decline button uses shaming or fear wording			
4	Buyer must share data, subscribe or buy extra to access something advertised as free			
5	Cancellation of a subscription needs a call, an email or more than three clicks			
6	Any option is pre-selected by default (shipping, add-on, marketing consent, donation)			
7	The price on the product page differs from the amount on the payment screen			
8	Taxes, handling or platform fees appear only at the last step			
9	Paid placements or boosted products carry no visible label			
10	The site asks for the same thing more than once (app install, notifications, newsletter)			
11	Any checkbox is worded so the buyer cannot tell what ticking means			
12	Auto-renewal is not disclosed next to the price before payment			
13	Any download, extension or third-party script is pushed at checkout			

#	Check	Yes / No	Screen or URL	Fix by
14	Stock counts or "X people viewing" numbers are not real			
15	Refund or return terms appear only after payment			

4.4 The nine fixes that clear most small stores

1. **Show the final number early.** Put taxes and any handling fee on the product card, or at the top of the cart. FirstCry's Rs 2 lakh penalty was for exactly the gap between "inclusive of all taxes" and a GST line at checkout.
2. **Nothing pre-ticked. Ever.** No donation, no wrap, no insurance, no membership, no marketing consent. PhysicsWallah Rs 5 lakh, PharmEasy Rs 1 lakh, SpiceJet Rs 1 lakh and BookMyShow's Re 1 all came from a pre-tick.
3. **Neutral decline wording.** "No thanks" is compliant. "No, I will take the risk" is not. IndiGo changed one sentence.
4. **One real countdown, or none.** If you use a timer, it must be true: one end time, per campaign, not per visitor, and not resetting on reload.
5. **Give cancellation the same prominence as signup.** A "Cancel subscription" button in the account menu, no phone call, no retention queue.
6. **Label every paid placement** on the card itself, in a colour that contrasts, at readable size.
7. **Consent in one click, not two.** Marketing consent unticked by default, worded positively, with the purpose stated.
8. **Free means free.** If you want the email, say "enter your email to get this" — do not label it free and gate it.
9. **Keep the audit file.** Date, auditor, screenshots before and after, list of fixes. If the CCPA asks in 2028 why you certified compliance, that file is your answer.

PART 5

The prior-price rule, in practice

The riskiest clause in the amendment for a small store, and the only one that needs a spreadsheet

5.1 What the rule actually asks

Rule 4(13) says: where an e-commerce entity **or the seller** announces a price reduction, it must indicate the prior price along with the reduced price. The Explanation defines prior price as the lowest price at which the goods or services were offered during the **preceding thirty days**.

Three things follow. It applies to sellers, not just platforms — so a marketplace seller running its own "40% off" creative is inside the rule. It applies to any announcement of a price reduction, which includes a strike-through, a "was/now" badge, a percentage-off banner and a sale landing page. And it is measured on **the price you actually offered**, not on MRP.

5.2 The honest reading and the conservative reading

The clause is new and there is no enforcement record yet, so two readings are in circulation. The narrow reading: the duty is triggered only when you show a struck-through reference price. The conservative reading: any discount claim — including "50% off MRP" — should be accompanied by the lowest price in the last thirty days, because that is the only number the rule allows you to treat as the prior price.

This kit recommends the conservative reading, for a practical reason. The narrow reading survives only if your strike-through figure happens to equal your thirty-day low. The moment a buyer screenshots a "was Rs 2,499" against a price you charged at Rs 1,199 last month, you are explaining the difference to a regulator, and "we meant MRP" is the answer FirstCry gave.

The safe formula

Show three numbers, and only three: MRP (as printed on the pack or your list price), the lowest price in the last 30 days, and today's price. If today's price equals the 30-day low, say "our lowest price in 30 days" and skip the discount claim entirely. That single sentence is both honest and, in practice, more persuasive than a fake 70% off.

5.3 The 30-day price log

You cannot comply with a thirty-day lookback from memory. You need one table, updated daily, with these columns. A spreadsheet is enough; a nightly export from your store is better.

Column	What goes in it	Why
Date	The date the price applied (IST)	The lookback window is calendar days, not business days
SKU / variant	Product code including size, colour, pack	The prior price is per product, not per category

Column	What goes in it	Why
Selling price	The price a buyer could actually pay, after discount, before shipping	This is the number the rule is about
List / MRP	Printed MRP or your list price	For the honest "off MRP" comparison, kept separate
Mandatory add-ons	Tax treatment: inclusive or exclusive	Drip pricing is judged on the same gap
Channel	Own site, Amazon, Flipkart, Meesho, retail	Per-channel lows differ; keep them apart
Campaign	Sale name, if any	Lets you show the 30-day low was not a one-day spike

Two operating rules make the log work. First, write the price **at the moment it goes live**, not at month end from invoices — invoice data lags by days and misses short campaign prices. Second, snapshot the storefront daily (a screenshot per SKU or a full-page PDF of the category) so that if a dispute arises you have the buyer-facing number, not just your database value.

5.4 Three compliant display formats

Format A — the 30-day low. "Rs 1,299 — our lowest price in the last 30 days." Use when today's price equals the low. No strike-through needed.

Format B — prior price plus reduced price. "Rs 1,899 Rs 1,299." Use only when Rs 1,899 genuinely was the lowest price you offered at some point in the preceding 30 days — for example, a product launched at Rs 1,899 three weeks ago and cut this week. Show the window: "lowest price in the 30 days before this offer: Rs 1,899".

Format C — MRP comparison, clearly labelled as such. "MRP Rs 2,499. Our price Rs 1,299. Lowest price in the last 30 days: Rs 1,299." This is the format for FMCG-style packs where MRP is a legal concept and buyers expect to see it. Note that it shows a 48% "discount" off MRP while the honest 30-day comparison is nil — which is exactly the transparency the rule is designed to produce.

5.5 Five habits to stop this week

1. Inflating MRP on your own label to manufacture a discount. MRP is a declared retail sale price; declaring a fake one is a Legal Metrology problem on top of a consumer-law problem.
2. A "sale" that never ends. If the banner has run for eight months, the prior price is the sale price.
3. Per-visitor timers and per-visitor "only 3 left" counts. False urgency, and now visible to anyone who opens a private window.
4. Discount claims on the marketplace listing that do not match your own site. The marketplace's Rule 4(13) compliance is built on your price feed.
5. "Up to 70% off" as the only price statement on a category page, with the qualifying products invisible. Either name the products or drop the claim.

PART 6

The grievance officer and the NCH partnership

Two registrations, one SOP, four emails — the most verifiable obligation in the amendment

6.1 Appoint and display

Rule 4(4) requires a grievance officer; Rule 4(2) requires their email, landline and mobile to be displayed; Rule 4(5) gives them 48 hours to acknowledge and one month to resolve. In a small company the grievance officer is usually the founder, and that is fine — what is not fine is a generic support inbox with nobody accountable.

Publish the block from Part 3.1 on your contact page, and repeat the officer's name and email in the footer of every order email. Then write the SOP down, because the 48-hour clock does not care whether you were travelling.

6.2 Registering on the National Consumer Helpline

Rule 4(7) is a registration, not a policy. The National Consumer Helpline runs a **convergence** programme in which companies join as partners so that complaints reach them before they escalate; the government told Parliament in August 2026 that 1,853 companies participate, and that the helpline accepts grievances in 17 languages through its portal, its app, UMANG and WhatsApp.

The route is the Convergence Company Registration form on the National Consumer Helpline portal (consumerhelpline.gov.in). The portal asks for a company login, the registered company name, whether the company is registered with the Registrar of Companies and its CIN if so, and a short company profile naming the brand and website. Two documents are downloadable from the same page and must be completed and uploaded: an **authorisation letter** and a **company undertaking letter**.

Practical sequence. (1) Download both letters and put them on your letterhead, signed by a director or proprietor. (2) Keep your GST certificate, incorporation certificate or Udyam registration, and PAN handy. (3) Fill the form with the legal name exactly as on those documents — mismatches are the usual reason a registration bounces. (4) Once approved, save the login in your password manager with two named owners, not one. (5) Test it: file a dummy complaint from a personal account and confirm it appears in your dashboard, so you learn the interface before a real buyer does.

Why this one matters more than it looks

Every other obligation in the amendment is something the regulator has to come and check. This one is a list. Being absent from the convergence programme is a visible, checkable fact on 2 January 2027 — and it is the first thing a compliance reviewer, an investor's diligence team or a marketplace's onboarding check will look for.

6.3 The internal SOP

When	What happens	Who
Day 0	Complaint lands (email, NCH dashboard, marketplace, WhatsApp, social). Log it in the register with a ticket number, the order ID and the amount at stake	Support
Within 24 hours	Send the acknowledgement with the numbered record of the complaint (Template 1)	Grievance officer
Within 48 hours	Rule 4(5) deadline for acknowledgement and the copy of the complaint. This is the hard one	Grievance officer
Day 2–7	Investigate: order trail, courier proof, payment record, warehouse photo, call recording. Send one interim update even if there is nothing to report	Support + ops
Day 7–25	Resolve: refund, replacement, credit note, or a written reasoned rejection. Send Template 3 or 4	Grievance officer
Day 30	Rule 4(5) outer limit. If unresolved, say so in writing, state what is pending and by when, and offer the escalation path	Grievance officer
Monthly	Review the register: volume, causes, repeat SKUs, repeat couriers. Fix one root cause a month	Founder

6.4 The four templates

Copy these into your helpdesk as canned replies. Each is short on purpose: a long letter reads as evasion, a numbered one reads as a record.

Template 1 — acknowledgement and record of complaint (send within 48 hours)

Subject: Your complaint [TICKET] — our record of what you told us

Dear [Name],

Thank you for writing on [date]. We have recorded your complaint as follows. Please read it and reply within seven days if anything is inaccurate or missing, because this is the record we will work from.

1. Order number: [order ID], placed on [date]
2. Product or service: [name, variant, quantity]
3. Amount paid: Rs [amount], by [method]
4. What you told us: [2–3 sentences in the buyer's own words, no interpretation]
5. What you are asking for: [refund / replacement / repair / explanation / other]
6. Our ticket number: [TICKET]

We will respond substantively by [date, within one month of receipt]. If we need anything from you — a photograph, a courier receipt, an unboxing video — we will ask for it in one email, not several.

[Name], Grievance Officer
[email] | [landline] | [mobile]
[Legal name of the company], [address]

Template 2 — interim update (day 3–7)

Subject: Your complaint [TICKET] — update

Dear [Name],

An update so you are not left guessing. We have [checked the dispatch record / asked the courier for a proof of delivery / pulled the payment log / inspected the returned item].

What we know so far: [one or two sentences, factual].
What is still pending: [one sentence].
When you will hear from us next: [date].

If your situation has changed — for example the item has arrived — reply to this email and we will close the ticket.

[Name], Grievance Officer

Template 3 — resolution

Subject: Your complaint [TICKET] — resolved

Dear [Name],

We have completed your complaint.

What we found: [two sentences, including our mistake if we made one].
What we have done: [refund of Rs X initiated on date, expected in the account in 5–7 working days / replacement dispatched with tracking / repair completed].
What we have changed so this does not repeat: [one sentence — a real change, not a promise].

Your ticket is closed. If the refund has not reached you by [date], reply to this email and we will reopen it the same day.

[Name], Grievance Officer

Template 4 — reasoned rejection (day 7–25)

Subject: Your complaint [TICKET] — our decision and your options

Dear [Name],

We have completed our review and, unfortunately, we are not able to [refund / replace] this order. Here is our reasoning, so you can judge it.

1. Your complaint: [one line].
2. What we found: [the evidence — delivery proof, the policy clause, the inspection note].
3. Why that leads to this decision: [two sentences].
4. What we can still do: [goodwill credit / partial refund / repair at cost / nothing].

If you disagree, you may escalate to the National Consumer Helpline, where we are a registered convergence partner, or to the District Consumer Commission. We will cooperate with either process and we will not treat this complaint as closed until you tell us it is.

[Name], Grievance Officer

PART 7

Sponsored placements, ranking and search

The three clauses that turn your merchandising decisions into disclosures

7.1 Labelling sponsored placements

Rule 4(12) requires sponsored listings to be **distinctly identified** with **clear and prominent disclosures**. In practice that means a word, on the card, that a buyer reading quickly cannot miss.

Do	Do not
"Sponsored" in a contrasting chip at the top-left of the card, at least the size of the price	A grey "Ad" in 9px on a grey card
"Paid placement" in the results header when a whole row is bought	A tooltip behind an information icon
A one-line explanation on the category page: "Some products here are promoted by sellers; this affects their position, not their price"	"Promoted" that appears only on hover, or only on mobile after a tap
The label present in search results, category pages, recommendation rails and cross-sell blocks	Labelling on the website but not in the app, or the reverse

The rule covers "sponsored listing of products and services", so it reaches beyond search: a "You may also like" slot you sold to a brand, a banner carousel with paid slots, a "Featured store" tile. If money changed hands for the position, the position gets a label.

7.2 Publishing your ranking parameters

Rule 5(3)(f) requires a marketplace to explain the main parameters used to rank goods and sellers. "Our proprietary algorithm" is precisely the answer the clause exists to end. Publish a short page with the parameters in order of weight, in plain language. Here is a template you can adapt in ten minutes.

Paste this — "How we rank products"

When you search or browse on [store], the order of results is decided by these parameters, in roughly this order of importance:

1. Relevance — whether the product matches what you searched for: the words in the title, the category, the attributes.
2. Availability — items in stock and deliverable to your PIN code appear above items that are not.
3. Past performance — how often this product was bought, returned and reviewed well by buyers in your city.
4. Price and delivery speed — including whether the item qualifies for faster delivery to your address.
5. Seller performance — cancellation rate, dispatch time and rating of the seller.
6. Paid promotion — some slots are sponsored. These are always labelled "Sponsored" on the card and in the results header.

Paid promotion can move a product up the page. It does not change the price you pay, and sponsored products are never mixed into results without a label. We do not change your search results to show you products that do not match your query.

Last reviewed: [date]. Owner: [name, designation].

7.3 Search manipulation

Rule 4(11)(c) forbids misleading users by manipulating search results or search indexes having regard to the user's search query, and the new definition of "ranking" in Rule 3(1)(j) covers any ordering by any technology — including a model that reorders results. The compliance test is simple: for a query, does every result on page one actually match the query?

Three ways small stores fail this without meaning to. A synonym list built by a growth marketer that maps "cheap" to your highest-margin category. A manual "pin to top" override left in place after a campaign. A recommendations model trained on margin rather than relevance that is presented as search. Each is fixable in an afternoon: export your top twenty queries, check page one for each, and remove any override that returns non-matching items.

PART 8

Imports, and the declarations the law already required

Rule 4(6) points at a rulebook most sellers have never opened — the Legal Metrology (Packaged Commodities) Rules, 2011

8.1 What Rule 4(6) adds

For imported goods, the e-commerce entity must give the name and details of the importer from whom it bought the goods (or who sells on the platform), and must provide for identification of the goods together with the **full and complete name of the country of origin**, as provided under the Legal Metrology (Packaged Commodities) Rules, 2011. The reference matters: the country-of-origin standard is not whatever your catalogue says, it is the standard in the metrology rules.

8.2 The declarations that already apply online

Rule 6(10) of the Legal Metrology (Packaged Commodities) Rules, 2011 requires an e-commerce entity to ensure that the mandatory declarations under Rule 6(1) are displayed on the digital and electronic network used for the transaction — with one exception: the month and year in which the commodity was manufactured, packed or imported need not be displayed online. For a marketplace model, the responsibility for the correctness of those declarations lies with the manufacturer, seller, dealer or importer, provided the platform's role is limited to providing access to a communication system, it does not initiate or modify the transmission, and it observes due diligence as an intermediary.

So the field set for an imported SKU is:

Declaration	What to print or display	Common failure
Name and address of the importer	Full legal name, address, and the importer's details as on the bill of entry	Only the brand name shown; importer blank
Country of origin	Full and complete name — "People's Republic of China", not "CN" or a flag	ISO code, or the country of assembly
Common or generic name	"Stainless steel water bottle", not the marketing name alone	Marketing name only
Net quantity	In the prescribed unit — g, kg, ml, l, or number of units	Missing on combo packs
Retail sale price	MRP in rupees, inclusive of all taxes	An MRP that is not the declared MRP
Consumer care details	Name, address, phone and email of the person who will answer	A generic support email with no name or address
Best before / use before	For products that have one, including food	Shown as a shelf-life claim instead of a date

The distinction that catches electronics resellers

Country of origin is where the goods were **wholly obtained or produced**, not where the box was assembled from imported parts, and not where the seller is registered. A product assembled in India from imported components is not automatically Indian-origin. If your supplier's invoice does not state origin, ask for it in writing before you list the SKU — the declaration on your listing is your representation.

PART 9

The fourteen-field listing sheet

Rule 6(5)(d) and (j) turned a product listing into a disclosure document. Here is the sheet, filled and blank

9.1 The fields

#	Field	Rule	Example
1	Product title with the generic name	6(5)(d)	Cotton Kurta for Women — Straight Fit, Hand Block Print, Indigo
2	Brand and manufacturer or packer	LMPC 6(1)	Made by: [name], [full address]
3	Country of origin	6(5)(d), 4(6)	India
4	Importer name and details (imports only)	4(6)	Imported by: [name], [address]
5	Net quantity and unit	LMPC 6(1)	1 piece; 220 g
6	MRP inclusive of all taxes	LMPC 6(1), 4(13)	MRP Rs 1,499 (inclusive of all taxes)
7	Selling price and 30-day prior price	4(13)	Rs 999. Lowest price in the last 30 days: Rs 999
8	Best before or use before	6(5)(d)	Best before 24 months from packing
9	Return window and conditions	6(5)(d), 7(1)(a)	7 days from delivery; unused, tags intact
10	Refund timeline and method	7(1)(a)	Refund to source in 5–7 working days after pickup
11	Exchange and warranty or guarantee	6(5)(d)	Exchange for size within 7 days; no warranty
12	Delivery and shipment	6(5)(d)	Dispatched in 2 working days; delivered in 3–7
13	Cost of return shipping	6(5)(d)	Free for defective items; Rs 79 for size exchange
14	GSTIN or MSME registration number	6(5)(j)	GSTIN 27ABCDE1234F1Z5 / Udyam UDYAM-MH-00-0000000

9.2 A filled example you can copy

Worked listing — a Rs 999 cotton kurta

Cotton Kurta for Women — Straight Fit, Hand Block Print, Indigo

Brand: [Brand]. Manufactured and packed by [legal name], [full address with PIN]. Country of origin: India. Net quantity: 1 piece. MRP Rs 1,499 inclusive of all taxes. Our price Rs 999. Lowest price in the last 30 days: Rs 999.

Fabric: 100% cotton. Wash care: cold hand wash, do not bleach, dry in shade. Best before: not applicable.

Delivery: dispatched within 2 working days; delivered in 3–7 working days to most PIN codes. Shipping free above Rs 799.

Returns: 7 days from delivery, unused with tags intact. Return shipping free if the item is defective or wrong; Rs 79 for a size exchange. Refund to the original payment method within 5–7 working days of pickup.

Warranty: none. Exchange: size exchange within 7 days subject to stock.

Seller: [legal name], GSTIN 27ABCDE1234F1Z5, Udyam UDYAM-MH-00-0000000.

Grievance officer: [name], [email], [landline], [mobile]. Complaints acknowledged within 48 hours and resolved within one month.

9.3 The blank sheet

Field	Your SKU 1	Your SKU 2	Your SKU 3
Title with generic name			
Brand / manufacturer / packer			
Country of origin			
Importer (if imported)			
Net quantity			
MRP inclusive of taxes			
Selling price			
30-day prior price			
Best before / use before			
Return window			
Refund timeline			
Warranty / guarantee			
Delivery timeline			
Cost of return shipping			
GSTIN / MSME number			

PART 10

The invoice

One clause, ten minutes, and a template that cannot get it wrong

Rule 4(14) requires the invoice to display the seller's name clearly and prominently, in the same font size as the e-commerce entity's name. The point is identification: the buyer must be able to see who they bought from without reading the fine print.

Do this. Open your invoice template. Set the seller's legal name in the header block, same type size and weight as your own brand name. If the platform generates the invoice, pull the last three order invoices and measure; if the seller name is smaller, raise it with seller support and keep the email as evidence of your request.

Invoice check	Done
Seller's legal name in the header, same font size as the platform or brand name	
GSTIN of the seller, and the place of supply	
HSN or SAC code for each line item	
Taxable value, CGST/SGST/IGST split, and the total in words	
MRP and the actual selling price per unit, where the two differ	
Country of origin for imported items	
Return and refund summary printed on the invoice itself	
Grievance officer's email and phone printed in the footer	
Invoice number series without gaps, and the date of supply	
Signed-off copy archived for the statutory period	

PART 11

The dark-pattern compliance certificate

Rule 4(15) requires a certificate, displayed prominently. Here is the text, the display rules and the audit log behind it

11.1 The certificate

Display it as a page of its own, linked in the footer as "Dark pattern compliance", and as a short statement inside your terms page. Name a signatory, a date and a period. Do not use the word "certified" in a way that suggests a third party audited you — this is a self-audit, and the rule says so.

Paste this

Dark Pattern Compliance Statement — [legal name of the entity]

In accordance with Rule 4(15) of the Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Rules, 2020, as amended by the Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) (Amendment) Rules, 2026, [legal name] confirms that it has conducted its annual self-audit of its website and applications against the Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Dark Patterns, 2023, notified by the Central Consumer Protection Authority on 30 November 2023.

The audit covered the following interfaces: product pages, search and category results, cart, checkout, payment, subscription and account settings, and all promotional campaigns live during the audit period.

Findings: [n] instances across [n] of the thirteen specified patterns were identified and corrected. Corrective actions taken: [one line each]. Interfaces re-tested on [date].

On the basis of this self-audit, [legal name] confirms that its platform is free from the dark patterns specified in the said Guidelines as on the date of this statement. The next self-audit is scheduled for [date, 12 months out].

Audit period: [from] to [to]. Date of statement: [date].
Signed: [name], [designation], [legal name]. Contact: [grievance officer email].

11.2 The audit log

Keep a one-page log per audit. It is the evidence that the certificate is honest, and it is the document you will want if a complaint or a notice arrives eighteen months from now.

Item	Record
Date and duration of the audit	
Who conducted it (name, role, and whether external)	
Devices and browsers tested, including the app	

Item	Record
Screens tested, listed	
Patterns found, with screenshot file names	
Fix made, with the person responsible and the date	
Re-test result and date	
Certificate published on (URL) and version number	
Next audit due	

PART 12

The eight-week calendar

6 November 2026 to 31 December 2026. One page per fortnight, one owner per task

Week 1 — 6 to 12 November: know your role and register

☐ Decide your role under the Rules (Part 2) and write one sentence in your compliance file: "We are an inventory e-commerce entity and a seller on two marketplaces."
☐ Start the NCH convergence registration — download the authorisation and undertaking letters, put them on letterhead, sign, upload (Part 6.2).
☐ Appoint the grievance officer in writing, with a name, an email and a phone number. Tell the team who it is.
☐ Create the compliance folder: one place for the certificate, the audit log, the price log, the letters, the screenshots.

Week 2 — 13 to 19 November: identity and contact

☐ Publish the identity block (Part 3.1) on the contact page and in the footer of every page.
☐ Add the grievance officer's email, landline and mobile to the footer of every order email.
☐ Check that the phone numbers actually reach a human within one working day. Test from an outside number.
☐ Fix the legal name everywhere: invoices, terms, footer, GST display. One name, exactly as registered.

Week 3 — 20 to 26 November: pricing

☐ Build the 30-day price log (Part 5.3) and backfill the last 30 days from order data.
☐ Pick a display format for each SKU family: 30-day low, prior price plus reduced, or MRP comparison.
☐ Audit every live discount banner, timer and "was/now" badge against Rule 4(13).
☐ Kill every timer that resets and every stock count that is not real.
☐ Brief whoever writes campaign creatives: no prior price without the log.

Week 4 — 27 November to 3 December: the checkout

☐ Run the dark-pattern audit (Part 4.3) on a laptop, in a private window, with a real card.
☐ Remove every pre-tick: donation, wrap, insurance, membership, marketing consent, loyalty enrolment.
☐ Rewrite every decline option in neutral language.
☐ Show taxes and handling fees on the product card or at the top of the cart.
☐ Confirm the price on the product page equals the amount on the payment screen, for ten random SKUs.

Week 5 — 4 to 10 December: listings and invoices

☐ Fill the fourteen-field sheet (Part 9) for your top twenty SKUs, then for every category.
☐ Add GSTIN or MSME number to every listing, on your site and on every marketplace.
☐ State the cost of return shipping up front.
☐ Fix country of origin and importer details for every imported SKU (Part 8).

☐ Open the invoice template; equalise the font size of the seller's name (Part 10).

Week 6 — 11 to 17 December: disclosures and ranking

☐ Label every sponsored placement with a visible word on the card (Part 7.1).
☐ Publish the "How we rank products" page (Part 7.2).
☐ Test page one for your top twenty search queries; remove any override returning non-matching items.
☐ Publish your return, refund, exchange, warranty, delivery and payment terms as one page, quoted identically everywhere.
☐ Check that the marketplace listing text matches your own site for price, returns and warranty.

Week 7 — 18 to 24 December: grievance machinery

☐ Load the four templates into the helpdesk as canned replies (Part 6.4).
☐ Run a dummy complaint end to end and time the acknowledgement. It must be under 48 hours, including on a Sunday.
☐ Confirm the NCH registration is approved and the dashboard login works, with two named owners.
☐ Build the complaint register: ticket, date, order, amount, cause, outcome, days taken.
☐ Send one interim update on every open complaint older than three days.

Week 8 — 25 to 31 December: certify and file

☐ Re-run the audit after all fixes and record the re-test date.
☐ Publish the compliance certificate (Part 11) and link it in the footer.
☐ Complete the audit log with screenshots, names and dates.
☐ Diarise the next audit for the same week in 2027.
☐ Final read: Part 3 obligations ticked one by one, with the evidence file name against each.

PART 13

The printable checklists

Five pages to print, tick and file. This is the part you will actually use

13.1 Website compliance audit — 30 points

#	Check	Rule	Done
1	Legal name displayed, matching the GST or MSME certificate	4(2)	
2	Principal address of HQ and all branches displayed	4(2)	
3	Website name and details displayed	4(2)	
4	Customer care email, landline and mobile displayed	4(2)	
5	Grievance officer name, email, landline and mobile displayed	4(2), 4(4)	
6	Grievance acknowledgement sent within 48 hours in a live test	4(5)	
7	Copy of the complaint as recorded sent to the complainant	4(5)	
8	Resolution within one month, or a written status at day 30	4(5)	
9	Importer name and details on every imported SKU	4(6)	
10	Full country of origin on every imported SKU	4(6)	
11	NCH convergence registration completed and approved	4(7)	
12	Search results match the query for the top 20 searches	4(11)(c)	
13	No manual override returning non-matching products	4(11)(c)	
14	Sponsored placements labelled on the card, visibly	4(12)	
15	Prior price shown as the 30-day low, wherever a reduction is announced	4(13)	
16	30-day price log maintained and backfilled	4(13)	
17	Seller's name on the invoice at the same font size as the brand	4(14)	
18	Self-audit completed and dated	4(15)	

#	Check	Rule	Done
19	Compliance certificate published and linked in the footer	4(15)	
20	No pre-ticked options anywhere in the checkout	4(9), 4(15)	
21	Decline options worded neutrally	4(15)	
22	Final price shown before the payment step, taxes included	4(15)	
23	Subscription cancellation in three clicks or fewer	4(15)	
24	Marketing consent unticked by default	4(9)	
25	Ranking parameters published (marketplaces)	5(3)(f)	
26	Seller identity and ratings shown before purchase (marketplaces)	5(3)(a)	
27	No bundled fee for an unrelated service at checkout	5(7)	
28	Fourteen listing fields complete on every live SKU	6(5)(d)	
29	GSTIN or MSME number on every listing	6(5)(j)	
30	Return, refund, warranty, delivery and payment terms accurate and identical everywhere	7(1)(a)	

13.2 Evidence file — what to keep

If you are ever asked to demonstrate compliance, you will not be asked for an opinion. You will be asked for documents. Keep these nine, in one folder, dated.

☐ Screenshots of every page after the fix, with the date visible in the file name.
☐ The completed self-audit worksheet and the audit log.
☐ The published certificate, with its URL and the date it went live.
☐ The price log, exported monthly.
☐ The NCH registration approval and the dashboard login owner list.
☐ The grievance register, exported monthly.
☐ The appointment letter of the grievance officer.
☐ Three sample acknowledgement emails and their timestamps.
☐ The invoice template and three issued invoices.

13.3 Penalty exposure, at a glance

What could go wrong	Which provision bites	Realistic exposure
A pre-ticked add-on or a hidden fee	Unfair trade practice under 2(47); dark pattern under 4(15)	Rs 1–7 lakh, plus a direction to redesign

What could go wrong	Which provision bites	Realistic exposure
A discount claim against an inflated reference price	Misleading advertisement under 2(28); 4(13)	CCPA direction plus penalty; Rs 10 lakh ceiling for a first offence under section 89, Rs 50 lakh for a repeat
No grievance officer, or a complaint ignored for a month	4(2), 4(5)	Direction to comply; failure to comply moves to section 88 — up to 6 months or Rs 20 lakh
Not registered on NCH	4(7)	Visible non-compliance from 2 January 2027; direction to register
Wrong country of origin or a missing importer	4(6); Legal Metrology (Packaged Commodities) Rules, 2011	Consumer-law direction plus metrology action by the state controller
A listing with no GSTIN and no return terms	6(5)(d), 6(5)(j), 7(1)(a)	Marketplace suspension risk first, regulator action second

PART 14

Twenty questions we keep getting

The ones that decide whether you actually do this

14.1 Scope

1. I only sell on Amazon. Does any of this apply to me? Yes, as a seller: Rule 6(5)(d) and (j) and Rule 7(1)(a). The Rule 4 obligations sit on the marketplace, but it will push the new data fields onto you because its compliance depends on your data.

2. I sell digital products — PDFs, courses, templates. Do the Rules cover services? The Rules cover goods and services, and digital products are services. Rule 4 applies in full. Where a declaration does not fit — country of origin for a PDF — the equivalent disclosure is the delivery method, the licence terms and the refund policy for a non-returnable digital item.

3. I am a proprietorship with no company registration. Can I be a convergence partner? The registration form asks whether the company is registered with the Registrar of Companies and for a CIN if so, which contemplates unregistered entities too. Register in the legal name on your GST or Udyam certificate and use the same name everywhere.

4. My turnover is Rs 40 lakh. Am I too small to be noticed? The CCPA acted on a Rs 1 pre-tick at BookMyShow and a Rs 10 donation at PhysicsWallah. Size is not the filter; the pattern is.

5. I sell through an ONDC seller app. Who is the e-commerce entity? The seller app and the buyer app are the platforms; you remain a seller with Rule 6(5) and 7(1)(a) duties. Fill your catalogue attributes completely, because nobody downstream will do it for you.

14.2 Pricing

6. Does the 30-day rule apply to MRP-based discounts? The rule is triggered by announcing a price reduction, and the Explanation allows only one reference number: the lowest price in the preceding 30 days. The conservative reading in Part 5.2 is to show that number alongside any discount claim.

7. My product launched last week at Rs 1,899 and I cut it to Rs 1,299 today. Is Rs 1,899 a valid prior price? Yes — it was the lowest price at which you offered it during the preceding 30 days. State the window so the claim is auditable.

8. I run a permanent "sale" price. What is my prior price? The sale price. Which means you cannot claim a discount at all. That is the intended outcome.

9. Do I have to show MRP at all? For packaged goods, MRP is a Legal Metrology declaration, so yes. The 2026 Rules add the prior-price duty on top; the two numbers can differ, and Format C in Part 5.4 shows how to display both honestly.

10. Does a delivery charge count as drip pricing? Not if it is shown before the buyer commits — on the product page or at the top of the cart, calculated from the PIN code. It becomes drip pricing when it appears for the first time on the payment screen.

14.3 Grievances

11. What if the buyer refuses to give the information I need to investigate? Send the acknowledgement and record anyway, then state in writing what you asked for, when, and that the ticket is paused pending that information. A documented pause is not a breach of the one-month clock in spirit, though you should still close the ticket at day 30 with a written status.

12. Do WhatsApp complaints count? Yes. A complaint is a complaint. Your register should have a source column: email, NCH, marketplace, WhatsApp, phone, social.

13. Can the grievance officer be an external consultant? The rule requires an officer and published contact details; nothing stops you appointing someone outside the company, but the accountability stays with you, and the 48-hour clock is unforgiving of a part-time arrangement.

14. What happens to NCH complaints if I do not respond? The complaint escalates with your non-response on the record, and the CCPA can take it up. A convergence partnership you ignore is worse than one you never joined.

14.4 Practicalities

15. My marketplace invoice shows the seller name in small print. Is that my problem? The duty in Rule 4(14) is on the e-commerce entity, but the invoice carries your GSTIN and your customer. Raise it in writing, keep the ticket, and fix your own invoices first.

16. How long does the NCH registration take? It depends on the queue and on your documents matching. Start in week one; do not leave it to December.

17. Do I need a lawyer to sign the certificate? No. It is a self-audit statement, signed by you. It should be accurate, dated and supported by the audit log.

18. What if I find a dark pattern I cannot fix before 1 January? Fix the ones that take a plugin change first — pre-ticks, timers, fee display — and document a dated plan for the rest. A documented, dated remediation beats an undated promise, and it is what you would want to show.

19. Does any of this change my GST or invoicing obligations? The 2026 Rules add disclosure duties; they do not replace GST law, the Legal Metrology Rules or the FSS Act. Where two regimes overlap — MRP, country of origin, best-before — comply with the stricter one.

20. What should I do first, today? Open your checkout in a private window and remove every pre-tick. That is one hour, it is free, and it addresses the pattern that has produced the largest share of the penalties imposed so far.

PART 15

Sources

Every figure in this kit traces to one of these

Primary instruments. Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) (Amendment) Rules, 2026 — G.S.R. 789(E), Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution (Department of Consumer Affairs), notified 9 September 2026, published in the Gazette of India, Extraordinary, Part II, Section 3, Sub-section (i), notification number CG-DL-E-10092026-276125; in force 1 January 2027. Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Rules, 2020 — G.S.R. 462(E), 23 July 2020. Consumer Protection Act, 2019 (No. 35 of 2019). Legal Metrology (Packaged Commodities) Rules, 2011, in particular Rule 6(1) and Rule 6(10). Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Dark Patterns, 2023, notified by the Central Consumer Protection Authority on 30 November 2023.

Regulatory action. Central Consumer Protection Authority, advisory on self-audit by e-commerce platforms for dark patterns, 5 June 2025. CCPA order and press release on PhysicsWallah Limited and McAfee Software India Private Limited, 3 June 2026. CCPA order and press release on Digital Age Retail Pvt. Ltd. (FirstCry), 26 September 2025. CCPA order on SpiceJet Limited, 14 July 2026. Government of India replies in Parliament on dark patterns: Rajya Sabha, 4 August 2026, and Lok Sabha, Starred/Unstarred Question annexure dated 12 August 2026, which together carry the full list of nine platforms, the seven penalties totalling about Rs 20 lakh, and the list of 31 platforms that filed self-declarations.

Registers and portals. National Consumer Helpline, Convergence Programme and Convergence Company Registration, consumerhelpline.gov.in — the authorisation letter and company undertaking letter, the registration fields, and the statement that the helpline accepts grievances in 17 languages through the portal, the app, UMANG and WhatsApp, with 1,853 companies participating in the convergence programme as reported to Parliament in August 2026.

How to use these. If a figure in this kit and a figure on a government page disagree, the government page wins and you should assume the page is newer. Every rule quoted here was taken from the notified text in November 2026. Rules get amended; the certificate you sign should be based on the text in force on the date you sign it.

Final note

Compliance work has a bad reputation because most of it is written to protect the writer. This kit was written to be finished. If you do nothing else this quarter, do these five: remove every pre-tick, show the real 30-day price, publish the identity block with a phone number, register on the National Consumer Helpline, and run the thirteen-pattern audit once and keep the file. That is a weekend, and it clears the ground under most of the risk.